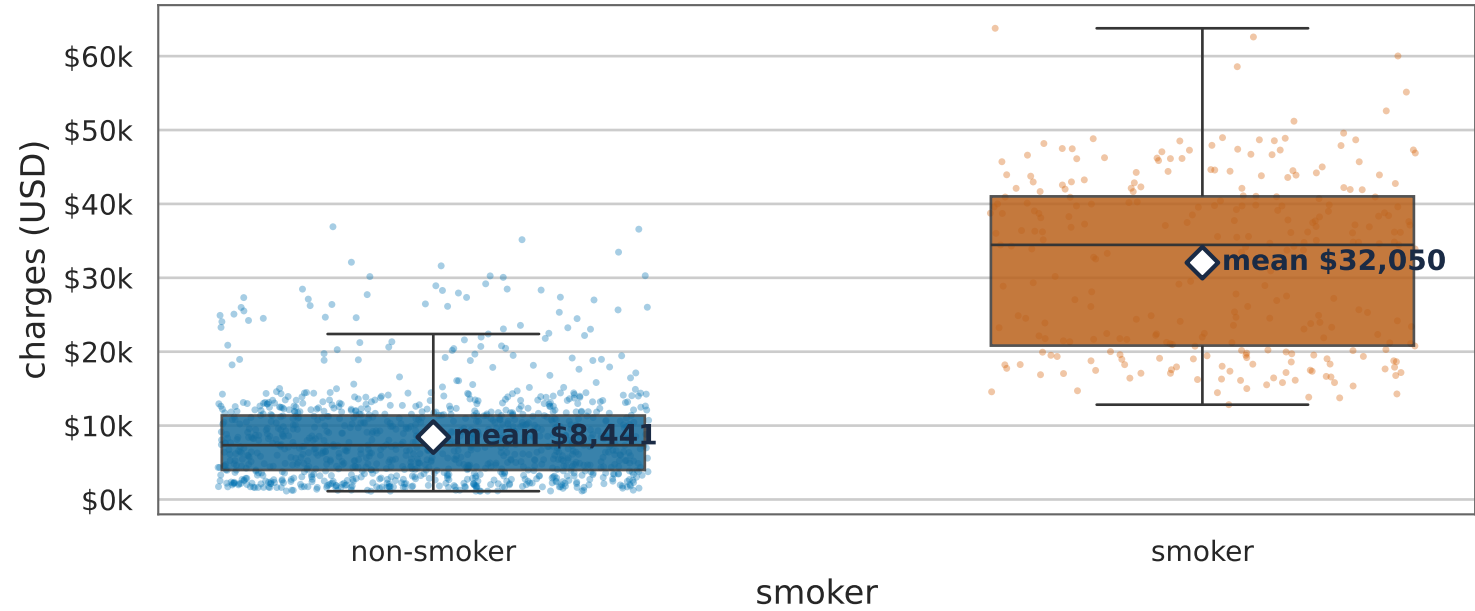


What Drives Medical Insurance Costs?

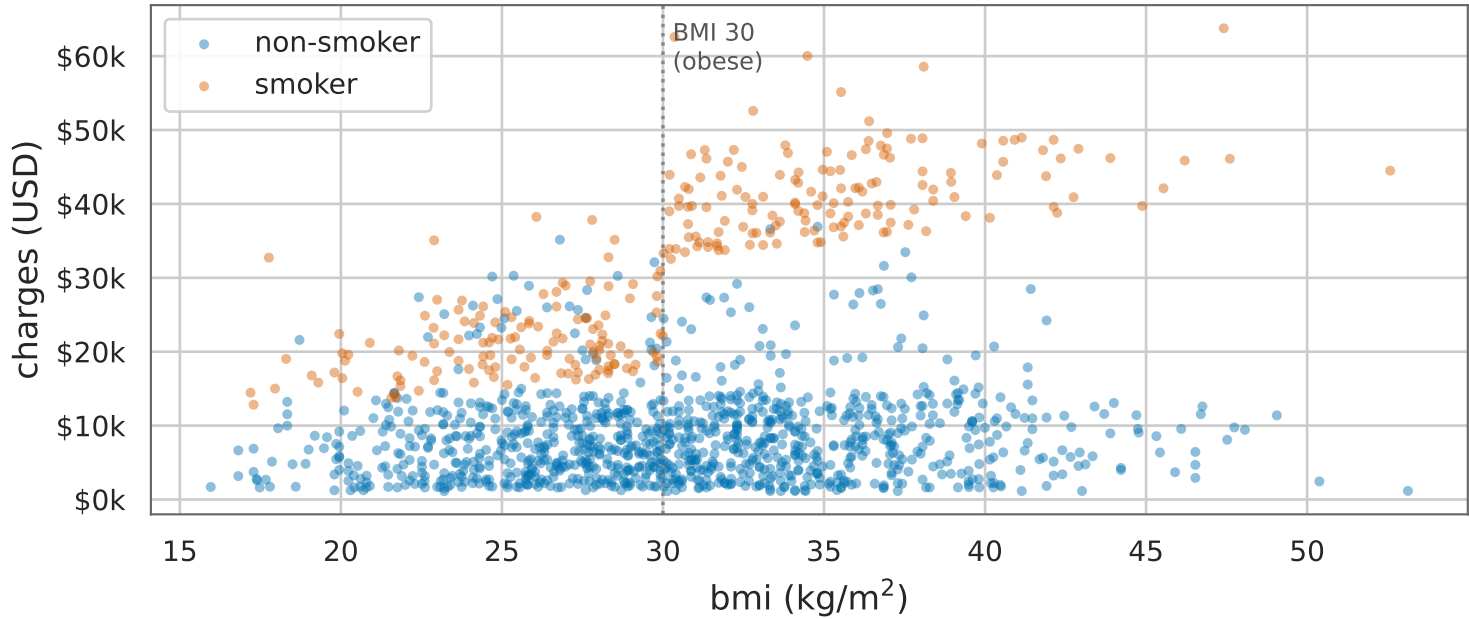
Smoking is the single dominant cost driver — and it compounds sharply with obesity. Age adds steadily; region and sex do not.



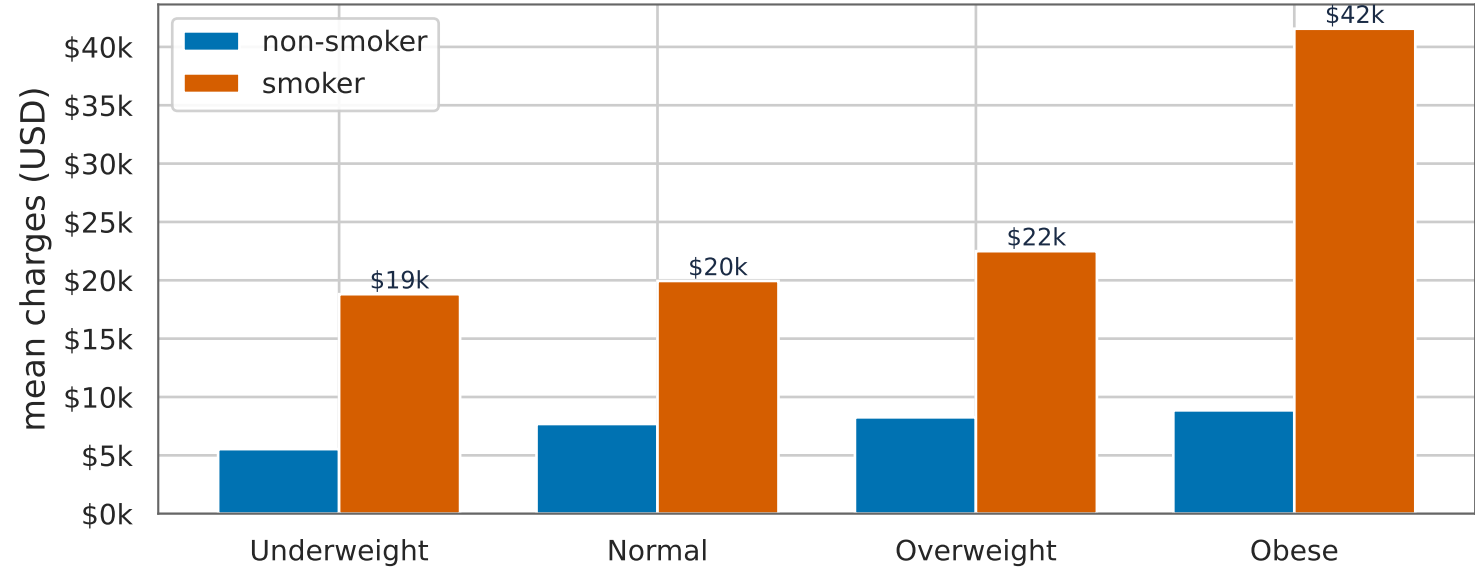
(a) Charges by smoking status



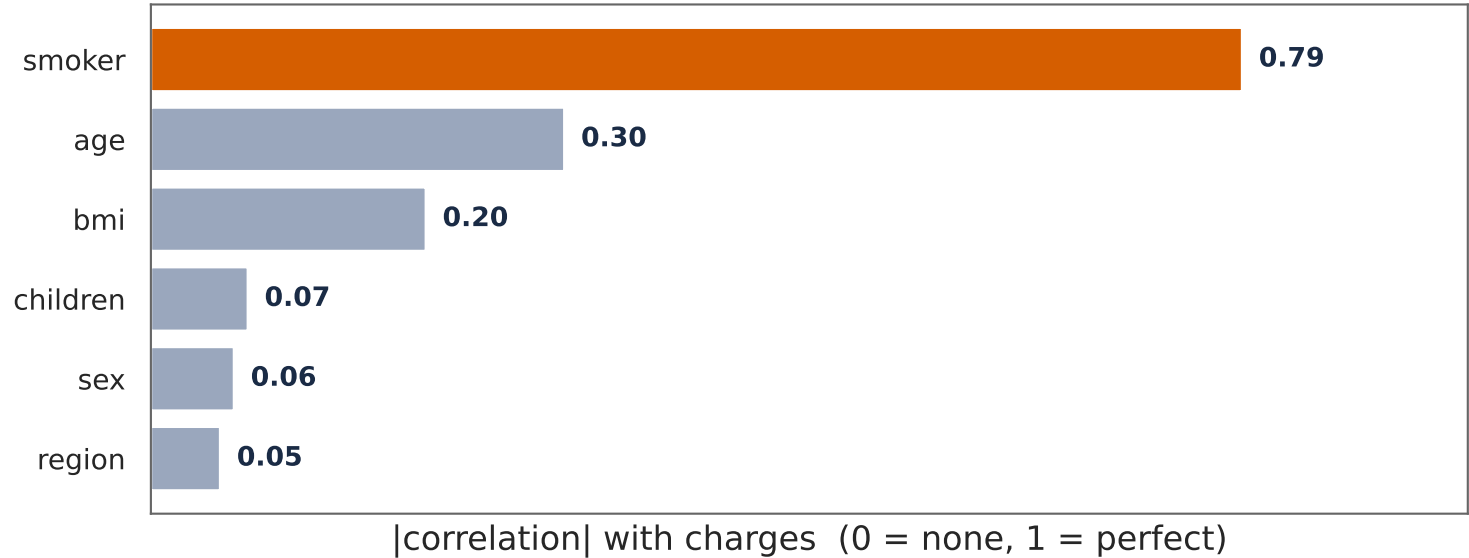
(b) The smoker x obesity interaction



(c) Obese smokers are the costliest segment



(d) Feature association with charges



Recommendation: price on a combined smoker x BMI risk tier (not a flat smoker surcharge), keep age banding, and drop region/sex as material rating factors.